

PORTFOLIO PARADOX

Can't get clients without portfolio.

Can't build portfolio without clients.

The paradox trap

Most beginners die in this loop.

Months pass. Motivation drains. Niche changes 4 times.

3 escapes. Pick one.

Each takes 1–2 weeks.

After, you'll have something to show.

Escape 1: Spec work

Pick 3 brands in your niche.

Write the copy you wish they had.

Publish it publicly with a 'here's what I'd change and why.'

Escape 2: Public teardowns

Pick 1 ad per week.

Break it down on LinkedIn: what works, what doesn't, what you'd test.

8 weeks = 8 teardowns = a body of work.

Escape 3: Strategy docs

Write 1-page strategy briefs for 5 prospects.

Send them unsolicited.

You're training for the job by doing the job.

Why prospects care about these

They're evidence of thinking, not execution.

Thinking is what they can't hire cheaply.

Execution they can.

Which one to pick first

Teardowns: if you like public accountability.

Strategy docs: if you prefer direct outreach.

Spec work: if you need to see polish on your own work first.

One rule

Whichever escape you pick, publish or send within 14 days.

Most beginners spend 14 weeks polishing 1 piece.

Stop waiting.

Pick one. Ship in 14 days.

Follow @csos for creative strategy breakdowns.